and Nexon. It produced power trains for several Tata vehicles such as Manza and still does for Tata Motors' Harrier SUV.

In 2008, a landmark deal was signed when Tata Motors acquired Jaguar Land Rover for $2.3 billion. That year, Tata Motors also launched the Indica Vista and unveiled the one-lakh car, the Tata Nano.

In 2009, the company launched the 'Tata Prima range of world standard trucks' and Tata Manza, 'the new generation Indigo'. It also acquired complete control of Hispano Carrocera SA. However, with the collapse of the global financial markets, the company faced a 'major decline in demand across its product range'.

The economic contraction of 2008 did not overwhelm Ratan. Though he realized that it would bring the group some pain, he had factored that it would be a passing phase. After having steered the company through large-scale changes, undertaken a plethora of foreign acquisitions and forged collaborations, he expressed confidence in Tata Motors earning respect in the 'global industry with meaningful size and scale in the various segments in which it operates'.

By the end of the first decade of the new century, Ratan and his team in Tata Motors had successfully implemented a major part of his restructuring programme. The company was on steroids. The stark improvement in design, quality, customer focus, cabin comfort of commercial vehicles, along with the foreign acquisitions significantly aided exports, something that Ratan had been strongly advocating.

Manjinder Singh Bansal, a second-generation Kenyan of Indian origin who had become a strong votary of the Tata brand after his stay at the Taj Hotel in Bombay in 1985 by happenchance, is the largest dealer of Tata Motors in Kenya. He says that the transformation in the company's commercial vehicles since 1991 is remarkable. New designs, tubeless tires, Cummins engines 'that had a big impact on Tata products' and impactful customer focus made Tata commercial vehicles attractive, he adds.

The customer focus that Tata Motors crafted surprised him, he confesses. When a Tata truck was bought, he says, the 'customer would get a call from India. If the customer was not happy, we got a call telling us that the customer is unhappy and [the question that followed it was] are you aware [of it]?' Several similar initiatives were taken, comments Niraj Srivastav, executive director (auto), Tata Africa Holdings (SA) Proprietary Limited. All these changes made some Tata vehicles market leaders and increased